institutions and social structures. The walls of American racial repression, intricate and elusive by design, built over centuries, maintained through quotidian actions, and upheld through his own administration's policies, as Robert Kennedy suggested, shared an uncanny quality with the Berlin Wall's concrete and barbed-wire Cold War border zones. Kennedy, in a passing revelation, demonstrated how imagined forms of citizenship and the injustices of racial segregation functioned as twin by-products of U.S. policy and history. The lack of attention paid to Robert Kennedy's acknowledgment of U.S.-built-and-maintained segregation in relation to the Berlin Wall highlights a political habit of downplaying racial and ethnic division, partition, and separation as fundamental practices of white-dominated American freedom.

A call to identify "our" own walls alongside Berlin's was not an isolated gesture by Kennedy of American connection with the German divided city. Berlin, on both sides of the nascent wall, was a site of pilgrimage to approach or meet the "entanglements and shared destinies" of American and German culture, as Maria Höhn and Martin Klimke suggest, after World War II and throughout the Cold War, especially through frameworks of race as well as gender, sexuality, class, nationality, and other modes of intersectional identity and belonging.[6] In this book, I extend that line of inquiry to argue that division was a central paradigm and paradox of the American Cold War democratic project, linking the geographies of home and abroad by way of the Berlin Wall. The stories of American travelers to Berlin, encountering the Wall and sprawling conditions of division, provoked an awakening and reckoning with structures of physical and social partition back home.

Robert Kennedy may have been one of the first politicians to step into a newly walled Berlin and refer to America's own global footprint and internal divides, especially around racial injustice. But his candid statement can be read as part of a much larger cultural dialogue that had quickly started to unfold in August 1961, within days of the first physical barricades bisecting the city. Almost immediately, American artists, writers, and activists, including those who sought the city as a place of engagement, began drawing attention to linkages between the Berlin Wall and barriers in U.S. democracy. Those barriers included racial segregation and later engaged the expansion of U.S. prison culture, the legacies of Japanese internment, and barriers reinforced through Cold War proxy battles. The